The Family Care Stress-Points Checklist

What to review, ask and write down while the arrangement is working.

You look after your husband, and it works, more or less. The list of what you do has grown one task at a time, and nobody has sat down to look at it. This page is a way to look. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something for a quiet hour, not a verdict on how things are going.

Review

- [ ] What you do for your husband in a typical week, written as a list, including the things that don't feel like care.
- [ ] Which of those tasks are new, or have changed, in the last year.
- [ ] What other people do for him, or what you think they do: the kids, a neighbor, anyone who already helps.
- [ ] Any regular task that was missed or late lately, written as what happened and on which day.

Ask

- [ ] Your husband, first: how he feels things are going, and what he'd want the family to know. [1]
- [ ] Each person who helps, one at a time: the one concern they would most want raised. [1]
- [ ] Yourself: which tasks you couldn't keep doing the way you do them now. Write the answer down, even if you're not ready to say it out loud.
- [ ] The family: a day and a time to talk about the unresolved subject that matters most.

Write down

- [ ] A real example for each concern: what happened, and when.
- [ ] What each concern is mostly about: the care itself, communication, paperwork or the workload.
- [ ] Where two people describe the same thing differently, both versions, side by side. Don't pick one.
- [ ] Any concern that belongs with a professional, written as a question for the person you'd take it to.
- [ ] An open-issues list: whatever isn't settled yet, kept where everyone can see it. One conversation doesn't have to finish it. [2]

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you look, ask and write things down. It doesn't say whether the arrangement is working, and it doesn't tell you that anything has to change. A checklist can't answer either of those, and this one doesn't try.

Ready for the next step?

You've looked over the week, asked around and started a list. The care interview goes through your husband's situation and the help around him area by area, including the parts that feel too ordinary to mention, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the National Institute on Aging's advice to check in regularly with the person being cared for and everyone who helps. The item marked 2 follows the Family Caregiver Alliance's point that one family meeting rarely covers everything. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting